

Beyond 10-Second Clips

Who amongst those of us with a capable cell phone doesn't like to shoot those occasional one-minute clips of video footage? It's as much fun, if not more, than clicking snaps — but those clips are usually destined to live and die on your cell phone, existing for probably a few days. So there you have it: we're all amateur videographers, and don't have the patience to indulge in it full-time.

Now when you think about how cheap camcorders are getting, the possibility opens up: you can actually make a hobby of it, going well beyond shooting friends getting drunk. If you have some free time and some free money as well, there are few nicer favours you can do yourselves than getting a camcorder and starting off on a truly rewarding venture: digital video.

It's all been dumbed down and made simple for the idiots amongst us: camcorders today are nothing like the strictly-professional equipment of some years ago. They're meant for you to use — right now. If you have the inclination, we have the book — the exact book. This one.

So here's how this little book is organised. First, you need to get to know your camcorder, and chapter 1 is dedicated to that. Then, chapter 2 takes you through all the format jargon your already-initiated friends are spouting all the time, and chapter 3 tells you what you can use to play the videos you shoot.

The fun begins with Chapter 4, which discusses video editing and capture tools; Chapters 5 and 6 are the meat of the book, telling you how to take your videos, and what to do with them once they're on your computer.

Chapter 7 is "optional", so to speak - it's about adding special effects to your video, which you might or might not want to do, depending on how hooked you've gotten. Finally, Chapter 8 goes on about putting your video online and where that'll get you. Our concluding Chapter is a bibliography, online and off.

There are better things to do with your free time than watch TV, and digital videography is one of the better indulgences. We hope this book gets you right on track!